state election commission (SEC) to revise and prepare rolls for the forthcoming local body polls. Announcing this, Karnataka law minister H.K. Patil ventured further to add that there was also an "erosion of confidence and credibility of EVMs".

IT'S THE STATE'S CALL

The SEC, an independent organisation set up in 1993 under the 73rd and 74th constitutional amendments, conducts elections to rural and urban local bodies—zilla, taluk and gram panchayats, municipal corporations, councils and the like. The typical procedure is to use the electoral lists of assembly polls for these. So far, only Kerala and Uttar Pradesh have empowered their SECs to prepare electoral rolls. Now, Karnataka will follow suit, amending rules where required.

Takeaways

- **The Karnataka cabinet clears the use of paper ballots for a series of coming local body polls**
- **The state election commission will be empowered to revise the voter lists for this**
- **So far, only UP and Kerala SECs have gone ahead with roll revision**

Upholding EVMs as a tried-and-tested system backed by the apex court, the BJP taunted the Siddaramaiah government, pointing out that it had come to power via voting machines. If it has lost faith in the devices, the "reasonable option for the government is to dissolve the assembly and go for fresh elections", quipped senior BJP legislator S. Suresh Kumar.

For the record, ballot papers have been the preferred method of conducting gram panchayat elections in Karnataka, though all other local body polls rely on EVMs. There's a long list of elections coming up. The terms of 5,950 gram panchayats end in December, and at least five city corporations and 192 municipal corporations will be due for polls shortly. Zilla panchayat polls have been held up since 2021 because the seat reservation lists are not ready. ■

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

CASTE DRIVES A HARD BARGAIN WITH HINDUTVA

The saffron 'big tent' is intact, but caste blocs are uniting to demand their pound of flesh in Yogiland

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

IN UTTAR PRADESH, 2014 HAD COME AS AN INFLECTION point for its post-Mandal political grammar. The BJP built a sweeping coalition by reframing identity in more omnibus religious terms, with Hindutva seeming to slather an adhesive all over the plurality of caste. For a decade, that strategy worked. It yielded two famous wins for the Yogi Adityanath electoral phenomenon. But today, with a cabinet reshuffle due and the assembly election less than two years away, the old caste equations are reasserting themselves in new ways, and the BJP finds itself negotiating pressures it had once claimed to transcend.

The signals are coming not from the Opposition but from within. Over the past month, Thakur, Kurmi and Lodh leaders have staged a series of community gatherings—framed as cultural or social events, but unmistakably political in tone. Each carried the same message: that these communities are crucial to the BJP's hold on UP, and they expect that importance to be reflected in government and party positions.

The Thakurs—paradoxically, Yogi's own cohort, and often said to be most favoured—were the first to flex their muscles. Forty of the state's 49 Thakur MLAs gathered at a Lucknow hotel on August 11 under the banner of 'Kutumb Parivar'. The next day, cabinet minister Jaiveer Singh convened another session with political bigwigs from the community. Among those present were transport minister Dayashankar Singh, Jansatta Dal (Loktantrik) founder Raghuraj Pratap Singh 'Raja Bhaiya' and expelled SP MLA Abhay Singh, besides plenty MLAs and ex-ministers.

THE COLLECTIVES

Thakurs—around 9 per cent of the state's population, and influential in 90-odd assembly seats and 20 Lok Sabha constituencies—already boast 43 of the BJP's 258 MLAs, its single-largest caste bloc. The scale of mobilisation has already been flagged to the BJP's central leadership, and names like Raja Bhaiya and Rakesh Pratap Singh are being mentioned as possible cabinet entrants.

A day later, Kurmi leaders gathered in Lucknow under the banner of the 'Sardar Patel Vaicharik Manch'. MPs, MLAs and ministers joined hands with senior office-bearers to project unity and demand greater representation. Kurmis make up about 10 per cent of UP's population and